Country Profile: Kazakhstan

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 8
- Plurality religion: Hanafi
- Official language: Kazakh
- Official religion: Secular state
- Core group: Kazakhs

Historical Background

Kazakhstan was the second-largest republic of the former Soviet Union. On October 25, 1991, it declared its sovereignty while remaining part of the USSR. However, on December 16, 1991, Kazakhstan declared its full independence, the last Soviet republic to do so. Since achieving independence, the country has not undergone any significant changes to its borders.[1]

Groups

- **Germans** are a minority group in Kazakhstan who arrived en masse during Stalin's deportations in the 1940s.[2] Following Kazakhstan's independence, their population began to decline as many repatriated to Germany. Today, they comprise approximately 1.1% of the total population, primarily concentrated in the central Karaganda Oblast, and in the north and east.[3] While German is their native language, Russian has become the primary spoken language among group members.[4] Religiously, about half identify as Protestants, while the remainder are non-religious or belong to a small minority of Roman Catholics.[5]

[1] Толымбеков, 2021.
[2] Minority rights, 2015a.
[3] National Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009.
[4] National Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009.
[5] Burgart, 2017.

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- **Kazakhs** form the core ethnic group in Kazakhstan. In 1989, they made up just 40% of the population, but their share has since increased to approximately 70%.[6] Kazakh, their mother tongue, is the official language of the country, though nearly all Kazakhs are also fluent in Russian.[7] The absolute majority of Kazakhs adhere to the Hanafi school of Sunni Islam.[8]
- **Russians** are the largest minority group in Kazakhstan, though their population share has declined from about 30% in the 1990s to around 15% in the 2010s.[9] They are primarily concentrated in northern Kazakhstan near the Russian border.[10] During the 1990s, Russians were involved in a self-determination movement advocating for northern Kazakhstan to join Russia.[11] Russian is their mother tongue and serves as a language for administration and communication, though it is not officially recognized as a state language. The vast majority of Russians in Kazakhstan are followers of the Russian Orthodox Church.[12]
- **Tatars** have been present in the territory of modern-day Kazakhstan since the 19th century and currently constitute around 1.1% of the total population, down from 2% in 1999.[13] While they are generally dispersed across the country, some concentration exists in the Almaty and Karaganda regions.[14] Tatar is their ancestral language, though most Tatars in Kazakhstan also speak Russian fluently.[15] The majority of Tatars follow the Hanafi school of Sunni Islam, with a small minority adhering to Russian Orthodoxy.[16]
- **Ukrainians** are a minority group in Kazakhstan whose share of the total population has declined from 3.6% at the time of independence to approximately 2% today.[17] They are primarily concentrated in Northern Kazakhstan. While Ukrainian is their

[6] Bureau of National Statistics of the Agency for Strategic Planning and Reforms the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2022; Demoscope, 2001.
[7] Bureau of National Statistics of the Agency for Strategic Planning and Reforms the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2022.
[8] National Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009.
[9] Bureau of National Statistics of the Agency for Strategic Planning and Reforms the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2022; National Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009.
[10] Bureau of National Statistics of the Agency for Strategic Planning and Reforms the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2022.
[11] Sambanis et al., 2018.
[12] Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009.
[13] Minority Rights, 2015c.
[14] Bureau of National Statistics of the Agency for Strategic Planning and Reforms the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2022.
[15] Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009.
[16] Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009.
[17] Bureau of National Statistics of the Agency for Strategic Planning and Reforms the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2022.

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ancestral language, the majority of Ukrainians in Kazakhstan predominantly speak Russian.[18] Most members of this community adhere to the Russian Orthodox Church.[19]

- **Koreans** were forcibly deported from the Russian Far East to Kazakhstan in 1937 under Stalin's policies.[20] Today, they make up less than 1% of the total population in Kazakhstan.[21] While Korean remains their ancestral language, extensive Russification during the Soviet period has resulted in the majority of Koreans in Kazakhstan speaking and understanding Russian fluently.[22] Their religious composition is highly diverse: nearly half identify as Christian (mostly Protestant), some 30% as non-religious, and around 11% as Buddhist.[23]
- **Uyghurs** first arrived in Kazakhstan during the 8th century. There was a significant migration wave in the 1960s when many fled to Soviet Kazakhstan to escape Chinese repression.[24] Today, they represent around 1.5% of the total population, primarily concentrated in the Almaty region.[25] They speak Uyghur and also have knowledge of Russian. The majority of Uyghurs in Kazakhstan practice Sunni Islam, following the Hanafi school.
- **Uzbeks** are a minority group in Kazakhstan whose population nearly doubled between 1989 and 2020. They now comprise around 3% of the total population.[26] They are concentrated primarily along the Kazakhstan-Uzbekistan border, particularly in the Chimkent and Zhambyl regions.[27] Uzbeks speak Northern Uzbek and are generally fluent in both Russian and Kazakh.[28] The majority of Uzbeks in Kazakhstan adhere to Sunni Islam, specifically the Hanafi school.

[18] Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009.
[19] Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009.
[20] Minority Rights, 2015b.
[21] Bureau of National Statistics of the Agency for Strategic Planning and Reforms the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2022.
[22] Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009.
[23] Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009; Ассамблея народа Казахстана, 2023.
[24] Minority rights, 2015d.
[25] Bureau of National Statistics of the Agency for Strategic Planning and Reforms the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2022.
[26] National Statistics of the Agency for strategic planning and reforms the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2022; Demoscope, 2001.
[27] Minority Rights, 2015e.
[28] Census results in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 2009.

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State Profile

Official Language

The linguistic provisions in Kazakhstan remained largely unchanged during the 1990–1991 constitutional amendments to the 1978 Kazakh SSR Constitution, which continued to recognize both Kazakh and Russian as primary languages of administration. Article 103 specified: "Laws of the Kazakh SSR, resolutions, and other acts of the Supreme Soviet of the Kazakh SSR are published in Kazakh and Russian."[29] Following independence, the 1993 Constitution of Kazakhstan officially recognized Kazakh as the sole state language, while designating Russian as a language of interethnic communication.[30] The 1995 Constitution upheld Kazakh as the only state language but allowed Russian to be used as a co-language of administration under Article 7: "The state language of the Republic of Kazakhstan shall be the Kazakh language. In state institutions and local self-administrative bodies, the Russian language shall be officially used on equal grounds along with the Kazakh language."[31]

Official Religion

Article 50 of the 1978 Constitution of the Kazakh SSR explicitly established the separation of church and state.[32] Following independence, the 1993 and 1995 Constitutions of Kazakhstan further reinforced this principle by officially declaring the country a secular state.

Education Policies

Schooling in Kazakhstan is compulsory and divided into primary (grades 1–4), basic secondary (grades 5–9), and general secondary education (grades 10–11/12), with an option to pursue vocational or secondary vocational training after completing grade 9. Children typically begin primary school at age 6. The curriculum—set by the Ministry of Education and overseen by the Ministry of Science and Higher Education—includes language studies (Kazakh or Russian depending on the region), mathematics, science, history, and a foreign language, with specialized programs offered for gifted students. After grade 9, students may continue in general secondary schools, attend vocational

[29] Constitution of Kazakh SSR, 1978.
[30] Constitution of Kazakhstan, 1993.
[31] Constitution of Kazakhstan, 1995.
[32] Constitution of Kazakh SSR, 1978.

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lyceums or colleges, or pursue professional education, all of which are largely state funded.[33]

Private schools are permitted in Kazakhstan and regulated by the 2007 Law on Education. The law requires all educational institutions, regardless of ownership, to provide instruction in Kazakh (the state language), Russian, and at least one foreign language, in accordance with national education standards. It also guarantees the right to receive education in native languages by supporting the creation of dedicated classes, groups, and institutions where feasible.[34]

Kazakhstan's Constitution explicitly prohibits all forms of racial discrimination, ensuring equality before the law for all individuals. The principle is reflected in the educational system, with **no segregation** based on race, ethnicity, language, or other categories.

There are **no affirmative action** policies in relation to the national minority groups in Kazakhstan. Some quotas have been established for Kazakh nationals who are not Kazakh citizens and live abroad, but they are not part of the NBP group list.[35]

Language Education Policies

Kazakhstan's language education policy is grounded in a series of legislative acts that recognize **Kazakh** as the state language and **Russian** as a widely used language. The 1989 Law on Languages in the Kazakh SSR (Articles 18 and 19) ensured the right of citizens to choose their language of instruction in Kazakh, Russian, or other languages. It also mandated both Russian and Kazakh as compulsory language subjects.[36] These provisions were reaffirmed in the 1992 Law on Education and the 1997 Law on Languages, which emphasized the right of national minorities to receive education in their native languages in areas of high concentration. Both laws also upheld the equal standing of Kazakh and Russian in schools, stipulating that: "Educational institutions provide an opportunity for free study of the Russian language, which is officially used on a par with the Kazakh language."[37] The 1999 and 2007 Laws on Education further reinforced the requirement to study Kazakh and Russian, as well as one foreign language. For instance, Article 9 of the 2007 Law on Education states that: "The state and Russian languages are

[33] Scholaro database, 2025.
[34] Law on Education, 2007. Article 9.
[35] Government of Kazakhstan, 2002.
[36] Law on Languages in Kazakh SSR, 1989.
[37] Law of the Republic of Kazakhstan, July 11, 1997.

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compulsory subjects included in the list of subjects during the final certification of students in secondary education organizations."[38]

In practice, primary and secondary education is available in Kazakh and Russian as languages of instruction throughout the country, with other minority languages, such as **Northern Uzbek** and **Uyghur**, offered in specific regions with large minority populations. For instance, there are 58 schools with Uzbek as the language of instruction and 14 for Uyghur. **Tatar**, **Ukrainian**, and **Korean** are primarily taught as language classes despite being formally allowed as languages of instruction.[39] **German** has a limited presence as an instructional language in some schools.

Religious Education Policies

Kazakhstan's public schools maintain a secular education system and do not provide religious instruction. In 2004, the elective course "Fundamentals of Religious Studies" was introduced following a presidential decree aimed at preventing terrorism and extremism. This course focuses only on general knowledge about religions and does not promote religious beliefs.[40] The State Program for Combating Religious Extremism and Terrorism (2013) reinforced this secular approach by mandating the introduction of a compulsory course, "Secularism and Fundamentals of Religious Studies," for grade 9 students beginning in the 2016 academic year.[41] The OSCE Toledo Guidelines confirm that this subject aims to expand students' understanding of religion as a social and cultural phenomenon, rather than providing faith-based instruction.[42] Kazakhstan's 2011 Law on Religious Activities and Religious Associations (Article 3) explicitly prohibits religious instruction in public schools, colleges, and universities, emphasizing the secular nature of the education system.[43] After-school religious instruction is permitted only if conducted by registered religious organizations.[44]

[38] Law on Education, 2007.
[39] Koreans in Kazakhstan, 2012; Osvitoria, 2022; Kazakh Congress of Tatars and Bashkirs, n.d.
[40] Seidumanova, 2020, 6.
[41] Ibid.
[42] Seidumanova, 2020.
[43] Law on Religious Activities and Religious Associations, no. 483-IV, 2011.
[44] U.S. Department of State, 2022.

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Bans and Restrictions

Religious restrictions on proselytizing, wearing religious symbols, and publications

Kazakhstan enforces several legal restrictions on religious expression, particularly in public and educational settings. The 2011 Law on Religious Activities and Religious Associations introduced regulations that prohibit the wearing of religious symbols, such as hijabs, in public schools.[45] The General Prosecutor's Office confirmed this restriction in 2016, stating that school uniform policies excluding religious elements comply with constitutional norms on freedom of conscience and education policy.[46] Additionally, this law bans proselytizing and religious activities in educational and leisure institutions for children. Furthermore, the law mandates state approval for the publication, distribution, and importation of religious materials, with only one copy of religious literature allowed for personal use without prior review. [47] Unregistered religious organizations are prohibited from operating, and religious parties are banned from engaging in political activities.[48]

Constitutions and Laws

On the eve of independence, the 1978 Constitution of the Kazakh SSR remained formally in force, although the series of amendments and constitutional laws adopted in 1990–1991 rendered it *de facto* obsolete, including the Declaration of State Sovereignty, which officially marked Kazakhstan's independence on December 16, 1991. The first Constitution of independent Kazakhstan was adopted in 1993, but it was replaced just two years later by the 1995 Constitution, which remains in force today.

The 1993 Constitution explicitly mentioned Kazakhs, affirming their right to obtain citizenship, including those living abroad. Article 4 stated: "All citizens of the republic who were forced to leave its territory, as well as Kazakhs living in other states, are recognized as having the right to citizenship of the Republic of Kazakhstan."[49] In contrast, the 1995 Constitution contains no explicit references to any ethnic group.

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[45] Electronic government, 2023.
[46] Today.kz, 2016.
[47] U.S. Department of State, 2022.
[48] Law on Religious Activities and Religious Associations, 2011.
[49] Constitution of Kazakhstan, 1993.

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Both post-independence constitutions uphold universal religious freedom and affirm Kazakhstan's status as a secular state. For instance, Article 22 of the 1995 Constitution guarantees: "Everyone shall have the right to freedom of conscience."[50]

Citizenship Laws

Kazakhstan's citizenship policy is primarily grounded in the principle of *jus sanguinis*. According to Article 3 of the Law on Citizenship of the Republic of Kazakhstan, enacted in 1991, citizenship is granted to individuals permanently residing in Kazakhstan at the time of the law's adoption, those born in Kazakhstani territory who are not citizens of another state, and individuals who acquire it through the legal process.[51] Importantly, there is no provision for birthright citizenship for children born to foreign parents (*jus soli)*. Article 11–1, added in 2011, explicitly states that a child born in Kazakhstan to two foreign parents is not eligible for citizenship by birth.[52]

The law also provides facilitated access to citizenship for former citizens of the Soviet Union and their descendants. Article 16 stipulates that citizens of the former Soviet republics who relocate to Kazakhstan for permanent residence and have close relatives who are Kazakh citizens—such as a child, spouse, parent, or grandparent—can acquire citizenship regardless of their period of residence.[53]

National Anthem(s)

Following its independence, Kazakhstan adopted a new national anthem in 1992, retaining the melody from its Soviet-era Kazakh SSR anthem but introducing new Kazakh-language lyrics that reflect national pride and historical struggles. The anthem references ancestors and honors mothers and the wisdom of past generations. Heroic deeds of the past are acknowledged through lines celebrating victory over adversity: "Emerging from malicious grip of fate, from hell of fire, We scored a victory of glory and success." The anthem highlights martyrdom and hardships endured in the nation's history, framing them as a testament to collective resilience: "We've overcome the hardships, Let the past serve bitter lesson." The anthem also refers to Kazakhstan's vast territory, describing the homeland as "the steppe, a sacred cradle." Notably, it employs ambiguous references to

[50] Constitution of Kazakhstan, 1995.
[51] Law on Citizenship in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 1991.
[52] Law of the Republic of Kazakhstan, no. 478-IV, 2011.
[53] Law on Citizenship in the Republic of Kazakhstan, 1991.

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nationhood without specifying any ethnic group, emphasizing national unity and strength: "For hero's might and strength is in the nation, Just as the unity is nation's razing sword."[54]

On January 6, 2006, Kazakhstan adopted a new national anthem, "My Kazakhstan". Originally written in 1958 in Kazakh, the anthem emphasizes national pride and historical continuity. References to ancestors are evident in the line: "From antiquity, Our heroic glory emerged." The anthem celebrates the nation's vast territory and unity: "The way was opened to posterity, I have a vast land. Its unity is proper." It also makes a direct reference to Kazakh identity and resilience, emphasizing the strength and pride of the Kazakh people: "They did not give up their pride, My Kazakh people are strong!"[55]

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[54] Nationanthem.info, 2025. Kazakhstan (1992–2006)
[55] Nationanthem.info, 2025. Kazakhstan (2006–)

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